

Vantage Engineering — Interview Process Guide

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1. Overview

This guide covers Vantage Engineering's technical interview process for software engineering, machine learning, and infrastructure roles. All interviewers must read this before conducting any interview. Consistency and fairness are non-negotiable — deviation from this process requires VP Engineering approval.

2. Interview Stages

Stage 1 — Recruiter Screen (30 min): Conducted by the recruiting team. Covers background, motivation, compensation expectations, and visa status. Interviewers do not participate. Outcome: advance or reject.

Stage 2 — Technical Phone Screen (60 min): One engineer conducts. One data structures and algorithms problem (LeetCode medium difficulty). One system design question appropriate to the level. Expected passing bar: working solution with explained trade-offs. No whiteboarding — candidate uses a shared code editor (CoderPad).

Stage 3 — Onsite Loop (4–5 hours): Four back-to-back interviews of 45 minutes each. See section 3 for breakdown. Lunch with the team (not evaluated). Debrief meeting same day if possible, never more than 48 hours later.

Stage 4 — Hiring Committee Review: All interview scorecards reviewed by a panel of three senior engineers who did not participate in the interviews. They make the final hire/no-hire recommendation. This prevents individual bias from dominating the outcome.

3. Onsite Interview Breakdown

Each onsite slot has a designated owner and a standardized question bank. Interviewers must use questions from the bank — do not improvise.

Slot A — Coding I (Data Structures & Algorithms): Two LeetCode-style problems. First should be solvable in 15 minutes, second in 25 minutes. Leave 5 minutes for questions. Evaluate: correctness, time/space complexity, ability to optimize under pressure.

Slot B — Coding II (Domain-Specific): For ML roles: implement a model evaluation metric, debug a training loop, or explain backpropagation. For backend roles: implement a rate limiter, design a cache, or parse a data format. For infrastructure: write a Terraform module, debug a Kubernetes manifest, or design a deployment pipeline.

Slot C — System Design: Open-ended design question. Examples: design a URL shortener, design a real-time notification system, design a distributed job queue. Evaluate: requirement gathering, component decomposition, scalability thinking, trade-off articulation. No single right answer — process matters more than solution.

Slot D — Behavioral (Leadership Principles): Conducted by an engineering manager. Five STAR-format questions covering: conflict resolution, handling failure, influencing without authority, prioritization under pressure, mentorship. Evaluate: self-awareness, accountability, growth mindset.

4. Scoring

All interviewers submit scorecards within 2 hours of the interview. Use the 1–4 scale: 1 = Strong No Hire, 2 = No Hire, 3 = Hire, 4 = Strong Hire. Include written justification — numeric score alone is insufficient and will be returned. Do not discuss scores with other interviewers before submitting your scorecard. Calibration happens at the debrief, not before.

5. Compensation Bands (Engineering)

All compensation is base salary + equity + benefits. Bands are adjusted annually in January.

Level	Title	Base Salary Range	Equity (4yr)
E3	Software Engineer I	\$130K – \$155K	\$80K – \$120K
E4	Software Engineer II	\$155K – \$185K	\$150K – \$200K
E5	Senior Software Engineer	\$185K – \$220K	\$250K – \$350K
E6	Staff Engineer	\$220K – \$260K	\$400K – \$600K
E7	Principal Engineer	\$260K – \$310K	\$600K – \$1M
ML3	ML Engineer I	\$145K – \$170K	\$100K – \$150K
ML4	ML Engineer II	\$170K – \$200K	\$180K – \$250K
ML5	Senior ML Engineer	\$200K – \$240K	\$300K – \$450K

6. Common Mistakes to Avoid

Do not ask questions about age, family status, nationality, religion, or health. Do not mention compensation ranges during the interview loop — that is handled by recruiting only. Do not make hiring decisions in the room — all decisions go through the hiring committee. Do not share interview questions outside Vantage — our question bank is confidential.

7. Accessibility and Accommodations

Candidates may request accommodations at any stage. Common accommodations: extended time on coding problems (up to 50% extra), written questions instead of verbal, screen reader-compatible coding environment, sign language interpreter. All accommodation requests are handled by recruiting — do not ask candidates why they need accommodations.